

Data Center News

The Battle of Homestead Foundation

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

Upper Burrell Township writes its own data-center rules

Upper Burrell Township supervisors voted unanimously October 22 to set tough local rules for data centers. New or expanded data centers must sit at least 1,000 feet from homes. Noise at the property line cannot top 75 decibels by day, or 65 at night. Water cooling must run in a closed loop, reusing the same water. Each backup generator may run no more than 120 hours a year. Developers pay for township studies; violations draw $500-a-day fines. Data centers must also supply their own power. Residents wanted an outright ban, but the solicitor said state law bars that. The township's six-month pause expires November 2.

https://www.wesanews.org/development-transportation/2026-10-22/upper-burrell-township-puts-limits-on-data-centers-with-new-ordinance (90.5 WESA)

House votes 202-1: data centers cannot become "public utilities"

The Pennsylvania House voted 202-1 on October 19 to bar commercial data centers from becoming public utilities. State Representative Chris Pielli (Democrat, Chester County) sponsored House Bill 2674. A public utility is a company the state regulates as an essential service. That status would let a developer ask the Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission (PUC) to seize private land through eminent domain and override local zoning rules. The bill now goes to the Senate, which passed its expected final voting day, October 21, without voting. Note: the House passed it just before this week's news window.

https://www.pahouse.com/InTheNews/NewsRelease/?id=145738 (Pennsylvania House of Representatives)

Union County to Allenwood developer: you jumped the gun

Union County officials are investigating whether PNK Group, a New York City developer, broke park rules by starting site work before winning approval. The county says PNK began work at 198 Enterprise Boulevard in Allenwood without approval. Commissioners also turned down PNK's substation request for three proposed data centers, saying the company gave too little detail and no look at its utility contract. PNK disputes that and says it completed extensive reviews before building. Gregg Township supervisors must decide by October 29 whether to allow data centers in the park. PNK wants a 252,000-square-foot data center in an existing building.

https://www.cnhinews.com/pennsylvania/news/article_e5e323a6-b6e8-5ecc-9906-f82da3949511.html (CNHI News / Williamsport Sun-Gazette)

Google and Voltus expand their "virtual power plant" tenfold

Google and Voltus, an energy company, announced October 22 that they will build a 1-gigawatt virtual power plant across the PJM grid region. A gigawatt is 1,000 megawatts. PJM Interconnection runs the grid for Pennsylvania and 12 other states plus Washington, D.C., serving 67 million people. It pools flexible electricity use — smart thermostats, batteries, factory equipment — and trims that use briefly when the grid strains. Participants earn bill savings and cash payments. The deal expands a 100-megawatt June agreement tenfold; Voltus will reach full capacity in three to four years. A virtual power plant trims peak demand; it does not replace a power plant.

https://blog.google/innovation-and-ai/infrastructure-and-cloud/global-network/virtual-power-plant-1-gigawatt/ (Google blog)

TWO DATES TO WATCH THIS WEEK

Springdale hearing: Wednesday, October 28, Springdale borough building; comments open through November 30. Gregg Township decides Allenwood Thursday, October 29.



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